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Skilled migration to emerging economies: the global competition for talent beyond the West

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ABSTRACT

Here we chart new trends in the globalization of human capital, and the implications of these trends for our current understanding of skilled international labour migration. Existing approaches to skilled migration have developed around the drivers and consequences of global talent mobility to and between traditional destinations in Europe and North America. However, in the emerging economies of South and Southeast Asia and the Arabian Peninsula, we find unique state regulatory frameworks, local labour market dynamics, and economic development trajectories that require new analytical approaches. Therefore, we review and re-examine existing approaches in light of the emergence of new players in the global competition for talent. We identify three strategies and examine cases from each: (1) global hubs for talent (Dubai and Singapore), (2) engaging with the diaspora (India and Malaysia), and (3) building local human capital (Saudi Arabia). Finally, we present an agenda to move the field forward.

KEYWORDS

Skilled migration; global talent; international migration; globalization; human capital

1. Introduction

Skilled international labour mobility reflects neoliberal globalization and the increasing importance of knowledge in the global economy. Scholars have documented a global competition for talent (Kerr, 2018) enacted through state labour market policies and immigration frameworks (Parsons et al., 2020), firm knowledge management practices (Faulconbridge et al., 2009), and urban development strategies (Florida, 2008). The result is a more complex geography of human capital, as ‘mobility and connections make the world brainier’ (Guest, 2019, p. 2). In recent years, the global landscape of skilled international labour migration has witnessed another shift that has received substantially less attention: the geography of talent has shifted beyond traditional hubs in the West with the emergence of new global centres of trade, finance, and industry. Rapidly globalizing economies in South and Southeast Asia (Yeoh & Lam, 2016) and the Arabian Peninsula (Ewers, 2013) have joined a growing number of places with clear policies to attract and recruit highly skilled workers. These and other ‘rising stars in the global race for skill’ (Cerna & Czaika, 2020, p. 1) are motivated by the same reasons as are more developed countries. However, by joining the competition for talent, these emerging

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economies challenge our understanding of skilled labour supply and demand dynamics, migration decision-making processes, and immigration policymaking.

Several scholars have noted the dearth of comparative and regional research on highly skilled migration outside of Western contexts, partly attributed to a lack of sufficient data (Bauder, 2017; Van Riemsdijk & Wang, 2017). The existing literature focuses largely on Europe and North America and therefore, does not offer suitable analytical frameworks to fully understand the inflows of highly skilled migrants (HSM) into emerging economies. In emerging economies, we must account for geographically specific demographic, economic, and political dynamics. For example, little is known about state policies to attract global talent in places such as the Arab Gulf states, India, Malaysia, and Singapore, what motivates highly skilled individuals to move to these countries, or how local labour market structures are evolving in response.

This paper seeks to address these lacunae with a review of existing literature and an examination of trends and policies in key emerging economies. In the first half of this article, we examine three key pillars for our understanding of skilled international labour migration, as a basis of critique and as a path to advance our understanding of emerging economies as destinations for skilled international labour migration. First, states formulate regulatory frameworks for immigration and employment to attract and utilize global human capital for local development, but our current understanding is based on mostly Western, liberal immigration states (Adamson & Tsourapas, 2020; Parsons et al., 2020). Second, international and regional labour supply and demand dynamics shape who goes where in the global economy, but existing literature does not account for the wide variety of highly skilled migrants or the factors that motivate their migration decisions (Skeldon, 2018; Van Riemsdijk & Wang, 2017). Finally, the literature on the incorporation of migrants in local labour markets does not fully capture the unique migrant divisions of labour found in non-Western contexts, nor the precarity facing highly skilled migrants everywhere (Ewers & Dicce, 2016; Zhan & Zhou, 2020). Thus, we review the development of these areas within the conventional migration literature and describe how and why these conventional understandings fall short in light of changing migration dynamics in emerging economies. In the second half of the paper, we critically examine these three pillars through case studies of major emerging destinations. Specifically, we identify distinct national-level strategies for engaging with HSM: building global hubs for talent (Dubai and Singapore), managing the diaspora (India and Malaysia), and developing local capacity (Saudi Arabia). We conclude by synthesizing these sections and providing an agenda to move the literature forward.

2. Highly skilled international labour mobility and rapidly globalizing areas

The migration of skilled international workers to the developing world emerged as an important trend in the 1970s and 1980s driven by, first, the globalization of production and related expatriation practices of multinational firms (MNCs) as they established subsidiaries and branch plants in the developing world, and second, rapid oil-related development in the Middle East and industrialization in the Asian tiger economies, which created a demand for technical skills not available in local markets (Findlay & Gould, 1989). HSM in certain sectors – engineering, construction, finance, and technology – facilitated the swift integration of emerging markets into the global economy (Krijnen et al., 2016). The following discussion addresses three key areas of the conventional HSM literature and describes how the arguments from this conventional literature relate to dynamics underlying skilled migration to rapidly globalizing areas: (1) state immigration and workforce regulation, (2) international labour supply and demand dynamics, and (3) local labour market outcomes.

2.1. State immigration and workforce regulation

States and their migration management frameworks play a critical role in regulating all international migration, including that of skilled international workers, by determining who is permitted inside a country's borders, under which conditions, for how long, and to what end (Anderson, 2013; Boucher & Gest, 2018; Hollifield, 2004). HSM are the objects of numerous state policies (e.g. Parsons et al., 2018), including skills- or points-based immigration frameworks, special 'talent' visas for individuals with extraordinary abilities, entrepreneurship or investor residency permits, and employer-based visas for specialty occupations.

Our understanding of state actions towards skilled migrants is derived primarily from the study of Western countries and advanced economies, which Adamson and Tsourapas (2020, p. 5) call 'liberal immigration states'. These states seek to balance liberal economic imperatives with exclusionary legal constructions that define social and territorial boundaries (Hollifield, 2004; Anderson, 2013). Yet, all states develop policies towards migration, immigration, and citizenship based on different priorities, including national skill and employment demands, economic and trade considerations, and political and geopolitical dynamics. Migration management regimes in the Global South may be built on migration as a source of nation-building, for the economic benefits of emigration and labour export, or even to monetize citizenship and the admission of migrants (Adamson & Tsourapas, 2020). Thus, it follows that regulatory frameworks towards skilled migration differ considerably as well. Much of the research on migration states in the Global South, however, emphasizes emigration dynamics, including forced migration, conflict, brain drain, and environmental factors (Bakewell et al., 2009). These topics are critical to migration studies more broadly but do not elucidate the regulatory dynamics shaping skilled migration in emerging economies.

Temporary workers surpass permanent immigrants worldwide (Skeldon, 2018), but an important incentive for migration to Western countries is the potential to convert a temporary work visa to permanent residency, and ultimately, to citizenship. Citizenship is the basis for fuller participation within a country's social, economic, and political institutions, even if other structures act to prevent such integration (Alba & Foner, 2015). Liberal immigration states can attract highly skilled workers and compete well in the race for talent because they offer such a path to citizenship (Shachar, 2006). This path may credit time spent in a country, learning the customs and language, and holding stable employment (Cohen, 2018). Conversely, emerging economies may only establish admission programmes for HSM on a temporary or short-term basis, with no prospect of citizenship. They may partially adopt migration management tools from the Global North or may innovate new strategies, as shown in the second half of this article. More research is needed to understand how these various state strategies affect skilled migrant lives, societal integration, and knowledge transmission within host countries.

HSM are likely to positively affect economic growth and knowledge creation in host countries if their human capital is fully utilized and situations of 'brain waste' are avoided (Lo et al., 2019). This requires that host countries have adequate stocks of local human capital and social integration mechanisms in place so that local populations can benefit from imported knowledge (Valdaliso et al., 2011). To facilitate local knowledge transfer and absorption, these talented migrants need a sense of inclusion, community, and security. Without the prospect of formal citizenship, migrants may look to informal social practices and alternative forms of belonging (Kathiravelu, 2012). Research in Europe, for example, has shown that social networks, including workplaces, migrant communities, and online social networks, are critical in 'grounding' HSM (Plöger & Becker, 2015, p. 1517).

2.2. *International labour supply and demand dynamics*

The conventional migration and development literature paints a general picture of skilled migrants as highly educated Western men, mobilized by multinational corporations, motivated by financial gain, and heading towards global cities. HSM, however, are extraordinarily diverse in terms of demographic characteristics and countries of origins, qualifications, occupations and industries, and motivations for migrating (Skeldon, 2018). They are not ‘homogeneously privileged’, according to Van Riemsdijk and Wang (2017, p. 2), nor are their skills and education equally evaluated by employers. While segments of the transnational business class do indeed globetrot via multinational enterprise, this is the exception rather than the rule amongst HSM. Many are self-initiated (Agha-Alikhani, 2016), using LinkedIn or other platforms to find positions with a specific company in the destination country, or utilizing executive search firms and other intermediaries (Van den Broek et al., 2016).

First, the conventional migration literature portrays HSM as rational actors, who plan and execute their actions based on economic costs and benefits, attributed to the higher level of return on their human capital in the new destination (Al Ariss et al., 2012). Many skilled individuals are attracted towards better employment and financial opportunities in a new location when conditions in their home countries are not promising (Kerr, Kerr, et al., 2017). Yet, many others decide – or more accurately are pushed – to migrate following natural or man-made catastrophes such as civil wars, political unrest, or deportation, which do not necessarily discriminate according to skill level and illuminate the shared experiences of immobility across migrant groups (Babar et al., 2019). Non-economic factors also include amenities, which remain an important but controversial determinant of creative class migration (Florida, 2008). Indices of quality of life commonly rank non-Western countries ahead of their Western counterparts (CEOWORLD, 2019), especially places where one may find more time with friends and family, more manageable working hours, and greater opportunities for travel and cultural experiences (Matarrita-Cascante & Stocks, 2013).

Finally, there is a strong regional dimension to skilled migration dynamics. For example, between 2000 and 2013, migration to ASEAN countries increased by 80% with most of this migration being intra-regional (Hugo 2014). The largest proportion of migrants in Asia comprise individuals born in one Asian country having moved to another Asian country – about 66 million people in 2019. Still, about 45 million people left Asia for either Europe or North America, which raises the question of whether the emerging economies examined here are serving as escalator regions (IOM, 2019). Based on UN DESA (2019) data, the three largest migrant corridors in Asia are from India to the United Arab Emirates (UAE) (3.4 million migrants), from India to North America (also 3.4 million), and from India to Saudi Arabia (about 2.4 million).

2.3. *Local labour market outcomes*

Labour markets vary from place to place and are inherently local, reflecting the specific contexts of labour supply, demand, and regulation (Peck, 1996). Thus, there is not one common experience of HSM incorporation, but unique sites of segmentation, privilege, and discrimination. HSM incorporation is affected by racial, ethnic, and religious identities, making employment and advancement easier for some, and more restricted for others (Bauder, 2017; Banerjee, 2006); and one’s mobility is heavily influenced by the power of one’s passport (Henley & Partners, 2019). Among the millions fleeing the Syrian conflict for Europe, for instance, are some of the country’s most

highly skilled individuals (Kelly, 2019), who must leverage their Middle East-based qualifications and experience to start over in new labour markets.

We know that lower-skill and lower-wage migrants are exploited, but there is increasing recognition of how skilled migrants experience systemic, institutional, personal, and professional obstacles (Banerjee, 2006). By now we have an extensive body of scholarship on how the labour migration policies of places in Southwest and Southeast Asia have negatively impacted low-income migrants (e.g. Gardner et al., 2013). Yet, little attention has been paid to how HSM are regulated through various sponsorship systems or how other aspects of local labour law and policy affect their lived experiences. Without the prospect of citizenship, there may be new and different types of insecurity and instability for HSM in emerging economies.

From a socio-cultural perspective, the agglomeration of different nationalities, classes, and wealth levels will likely have important effects in these regions. Despite state policies to attract international talent, local citizens may resent foreign knowledge workers, who often receive wages far above the local market. In many emerging economies, one also has to consider colonial histories and the privileging of Western experts as a legacy of the past (Fechter & Walsh, 2010). Migrants can also experience differences in social or cultural norms, the freedom of expression, or religious laws that may manifest in the hiring and workplace practices of companies, or official government regulations on immigration. For example, women play a significant role in the global mobility of talent but the experiences of female HSM differ greatly between the Global North and South and across cultural regions, in part, because of gender and workplace norms (Bailey & Mulder, 2017).

Finally, migrants may or may not accumulate human, social, and cultural capital by moving to new countries and cities (Bauder, 2017). In most cases, the move to an emerging economy is not a one-way trip for permanent, long-term settlement. Yet, the literature says little about what happens to a skilled worker after deciding to move internationally, particularly to a less developed economy. Research on highly skilled migration from the developing world to Europe shows that international moves for career development are not always positive or easy experiences, either personally or professionally (Al Ariss, 2010). A key question for future research is whether hierarchies of escalator regions (e.g. Gordon, 2015) exist on a global scale, and how migration to one region impacts subsequent spatial and occupational mobility.

3. Varieties of human capital attraction and acquisition strategies

Skilled international migration reflects a powerful interaction between individuals and places (Van Riemsdijk & Wang, 2017) and, in rapidly globalizing economies, reflects patterns and processes not widely documented in Western cases. This includes how states and firms attract and retain talent, how HSM respond to these strategies, and how the resulting in-migration of foreign knowledge workers impacts local labour markets. These emerging economies, however, have employed different strategies depending on the purpose that foreign talent is serving.

3.1. Global hubs for talent: Dubai and Singapore

The city-states of Dubai and Singapore share a common aspiration: to act as global hubs for talent. Both owe some of their success to their geographic locations, histories as trading hubs, and relationships with more powerful neighbours.

3.1.1. Dubai

Dubai is one of the seven emirates of the United Arab Emirates. The capital of this federation, Abu Dhabi, controls about 6% of the world's proven oil reserves (Arabian Business, 2018). Despite never possessing significant oil of its own, Dubai, historically a regional trade centre, has used the UAE's money and location to serve as a key entrepot for goods traveling between the Far East and the West, and a stable base of operations for multinational corporations serving the broader Middle East (Davidson, 2008). Dubai's population of 3.4 million people is 78% foreign and its labour force is more than 95% foreign, of which 15% hold a university degree (Dubai Statistics Center, 2017). The composition of this foreign labour force by nationality is 82% Asian (primarily India, Pakistan, and Bangladesh), 6.4% non-Gulf Arab, and 3.5% North American and European nationalities (De Bel-Air, 2018a). As with the broader foreign labour force, most skilled migrants are from South Asia. Of the overall Dubai foreign population in 2016, 1.9 million were men and 800,000 were women. Yet, females are more highly represented in the skilled workforce: 24% of Dubai male expatriates and 32% of female expatriates held managerial and professional positions (De Bel-Air, 2018a).

There is tension between the global-urban ambitions of Dubai and the more conservative economic and labour policies of the UAE and, in particular, Abu Dhabi, which is the dominant seat of political power. Since the second major oil boom in 1998, Sheikh Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum of Dubai has taken a distinct path towards a post-oil economy with infrastructural projects aimed at attracting international trade, migration, and investment. Conversely, Sheikh Mohammed bin Zayed, the Crown Prince of Abu Dhabi, has led the emirate's economy with a more conservative approach. Still, UAE Vision 2021 aligns more with Dubai's strategy to become a competitive knowledge economy and a global hub for entrepreneurship (UAE Prime Minister's Office, 2019). Dubai will need to continuously attract and retain HSMs to achieve these aspirations. It is accomplishing this, in part, by relaxing some restrictions on immigration and improving job mobility. The *kafala* sponsorship system ties workers to a single employer for the duration of their time in the country, which is usually a 3-year contract for higher-skilled individuals (Hvidt, 2019). Under new rules, however, an individual with a bachelor's degree and a salary above \$3266 can change employers without a NOC or a waiting period (Zahra, 2017). The UAE also announced the development of a 10-year visa for professionals in medical, engineering, science, and technology fields and a 5-year work visa for high-performing students (Reynolds & Rizvi, 2018).

While anti-foreigner sentiments are not widespread in Dubai, the UAE overall is considerably more conservative, leading to some tensions within its minority citizenry. Emiratization – the nationalization of jobs currently held by foreigners – is a national-level project, meaning a UAE citizen from one of the other emirates should be given priority over foreigners in Dubai, resulting in significant precarity and vulnerability for HSM (Ewers & Dicce, 2016). Workers in Dubai are also informally paid according to their passports (Naithani & Jha, 2009). In addition to the fear of being unemployed and forced to leave the country, the cost of living has risen rapidly. Expatriate workers are required to pay rising portions of the housing and school costs, new government fees, and a Value Added Tax, which has potentially decreased the emirate's attractiveness (Fattah & Abeer, 2020).

3.1.2. Singapore

Like Dubai, Singapore has leveraged its location on the Straits of Malacca to become a centre for international finance, oil refining and shipping, and trade and logistics. Singapore has an educated

and skilled local population. However, the government believes that by attracting global talent, including with the prospect of permanent residency, the city-state can boost its local talent stocks and increase its reputation as a high-tech, knowledge-intensive economy (Yeoh & Lam, 2016). Of the country's 5.7 million people, about 2.1 million are non-residents or permanent residency holders (e.g. non-citizens); foreign workers comprise 38% of the Singapore workforce. Among non-residents, 12% are S Pass holders (mid-level skilled foreigners), 11% are employment pass holders (high-skilled), and 17% are dependents of permanent residents (Singapore Department of Statistics, 2019a, 2019b). The total foreign workforce is 44% Malaysian, 18% Chinese, and 6% Indonesian nationals (UN DESA, 2019).

Singapore seeks to achieve its global ambitions through liberal immigration, flexible corporate policies, and by attracting talented students. The government actively supports the growth of MNCs in the country as the main engine for accessing talent, who are often channelled and incorporated through intermediary executive search firms and a 'Global Mobility Industry' (Cranston, 2016, p. 2), resulting in more than 7000 MNCs using Singapore as their Asia-Pacific base (Jamrisko & Zhai, 2018). Singapore also tries to attract young talent (SkillsFuture, 2017) by offering scholarships and post-study opportunities for high achievers at its prestigious national universities and branches of Western universities (Ho & Tyson, 2017). Dependents of employment pass holders can also seek employment (Yeoh & Lam, 2016). Thus, these provisions are aimed at not only attracting but rooting foreign talent.

The influx of foreign talent, however, has led some native Singaporeans to believe that foreigners are only there for financial gain or lack loyalty to the country (Chacko, 2017b). There is also a popular view that companies give foreigners favouritism, and HSM live 'privileged lifestyles', with high incomes, luxury housing, and the best schools, while socializing only with other Western expatriates and local elites (Harvey & Beaverstock, 2017, p. 278). Such sentiments resulted in a tightening of migration policies in 2010, with fewer foreigners being granted permanent residency or citizenship. In 2019, the National Integration Council was established to foster positive relations between locals and foreigners (Chacko, 2017b). Despite the perception of HSM as privileged, migrant precarity in Singapore and other East Asian countries cut across divisions of nationality, skill, occupation, gender, and class (Platt et al., 2017). Recent research has identified significant precarity among skilled Chinese and Indian migrants (Zhan & Zhou, 2020). For example, since the signing of the India-Singapore Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement (CECA), there has been local hostility to what Singaporeans see as Indian workers taking jobs (Xinghui & Sim, 2020).

3.1.3. Bridge

Both Dubai and Singapore are trying to attract and retain professionals across various knowledge-intensive sectors, including through offering scholarships and post-study employment options to competitive international students. While Singapore's strategies are more advanced, Dubai is taking steps towards providing ways for these individuals to settle down long-term in the country. Both places face challenges in terms of national sentiment towards foreign populations, but small local populations and strong public support of national governments may insulate these city-states from anti-immigrant sentiment (Allison, 2017).

3.2. Managing the diaspora: India and Malaysia

India and Malaysia each need to manage their positions as skilled migrant-sending countries by leveraging the knowledge, experience, and financial capital of their diaspora, and attracting back

native skilled professionals (Cerna & Czaika, 2020). Here, it is the initial migration of talent *from* these countries that serves as an engine of knowledge-based economic growth (Rapoport, 2016). When skilled workers leave, they can foster transnational business networks and knowledge exchange with their home countries which may ultimately outweigh the loss of local talent.

3.2.1. India

India has a large population with a strong skilled and semi-skilled local labour force, and an increasing number of graduates looking for employment. Therefore, India has focused on generating investment and strengthening business ties, rather than bringing back Indians (Cerna & Czaika, 2020). In recognition of the investment and economic growth opportunities offered by engaging with its international diaspora, India has set up Special Economic Zones where national business laws do not apply and tax exemptions for exports and investments make it easier for overseas Indians and foreign companies to establish businesses. The government also offers tax exemptions for remittances sent to India (Jonkers, 2008). In 2004, India set up the Overseas Indian Affairs division, charged with developing networks between diverse Indian diaspora communities and local Indian institutions and businesses to enhance the flow of investment, remittances, knowledge, and goods (India Ministry of External Affairs, 2019). As Dual Citizenship is not allowed, Indians with foreign passports or children of former Indian citizens can (since 2004) apply for the Overseas Citizenship of India (OCI) card. While cardholders are not citizens or able to vote, they can freely enter and invest in the country and purchase real estate (India Bureau of Immigration, 2019). As of December 2018, there were about 31 million OCI cardholders (Indian Ministry of External Affairs, 2019).

Despite government regulations, Indian companies that are trying to attain global industry standards and break into global markets are hiring highly skilled Indians living abroad, regardless of Indian citizenship, as they already have valuable experience in international markets that they can apply to the local context (Kumar & Chhokar, 2019). While there are some scholarships and funded research programmes to attract back scientists, research suggests that skilled overseas Indian scientists and academics prefer to engage in transnational activities rather than return (Li et al., 2018). Yet, there are other reasons why Indians may want to return. For example, overseas Indians may look to secure more professionally challenging jobs, may see India as a better place to launch new products because of lower labour costs and better government support (Chacko, 2017a), or may want to look after aging parents or raise children. Beyond returning diaspora, in 2015, there were about 5.2 million migrants in India, primarily from Bangladesh (60%), Pakistan (21%), and Nepal (10%) (Connor, 2017).

3.2.2. Malaysia

Over the past two decades, the Malaysian government has developed policies and programmes to attract back its skilled diaspora as part of its plan to become a more dynamic and internationally oriented economy (Kassim, 2017). For example, the 11th Malaysia Plan (2016–2020) emphasizes the importance of investing in Malaysian cities specifically for attracting talent (Malaysia Ministry of Economic Affairs, 2016). TalentCorp is a key pillar in Malaysia's human capital acquisition and retention strategy (Kerr, Li, et al., 2017). This program, implemented in 2011, holds job fairs at foreign universities to hire Malaysian graduates and offers career development programmes for local students studying abroad (TalentCorp, 2019a). TalentCorp also manages the Returning Expert Programme that links returnees with top Malaysian employers and offers qualified individuals a reduced tax rate of 15% for the first five years and tax-free car purchase (TalentCorp, 2019b).

Malaysia has transformed its status from an emigrating country to a key immigration destination, especially in the region (Kassim, 2017). In 2017, there were about 3 million migrants in Malaysia (ILO, 2017), primarily from Indonesia (36%), Bangladesh (12%), and Myanmar (10%) (UN DESA, 2019). From this 3 million, there was roughly 41,000 employment pass (medium to high skilled) approvals. The government also developed a 'Resident Pass-Talent' visa, which is a 5- or 10-year renewable visa offered to qualified foreigners, aimed at attracting foreign talent in key industries with talent gaps. Skilled foreigners can bring family members to the country, with their jobs providing accommodation, medical insurance, and education for their children. In addition to being able to buy real estate and invest locally, spouses of RP-T holders can also work in the country (Kassim, 2017; TalentCorp, 2019c). Roughly 1000 resident pass talent applications were approved in 2018. However, there is precarity arising from differential treatment along with class and gender lines for migrants. Visa classes and employment regulations are different for low skilled, medium- and high-skilled foreigners, meaning that these groups receive different treatment. Moreover, gender plays a significant role here: 92% of Resident Pass-Talent applicants in Malaysia are men.

3.2.3. Bridge

India and Malaysia are both engaging with their diaspora to benefit from the human and social capital they have gained during their sojourn, as well as their emotional and familial ties to their home countries. Yet these two countries are taking somewhat different approaches to the same goal. India's government is more concerned with investment from overseas citizens in the economy than with bringing back Indians living abroad. In Malaysia, however, the government is actively involved in implementing and funding programmes to bring back native talent and to attract skilled foreigners.

Malaysia has important geopolitical relations and population ties with both India and Singapore. For example, Indians are employed across the skill and salary spectrum in Malaysia, including hundreds of thousands of high skilled Indian workers in IT, engineering, and finance. Meanwhile, neighbouring Singapore is an important destination for Malaysian HSM. Malaysians can enter Singapore and work for three months without applying for a work visa and thousands of Malaysians flock to Singapore every day for work (Ho & Tyson, 2017).

3.3. Building local capacity: Saudi Arabia and the Gulf States

The economies and labour markets of the six Arab Gulf states can generally be categorized according to their oil and gas resources and population sizes. Kuwait, Qatar, and UAE have large resource endowments and small national populations and can distribute their wealth among fewer people. Bahrain, Oman, and Saudi Arabia, despite varying resource endowments, each have significant population pressure. However, foreign workers comprise the majority of each country's labour force, from a high of 95% of all workers in the UAE to a low of 59% of the labour force in Saudi Arabia (GLMM, 2019). Thus, while the UAE (population of 9.6 million, 87% foreign) can afford to strategize more about attracting and retaining knowledge workers, Saudi Arabia (population of 34 million, 38% foreign) needs to focus on steadily increasing the proportion of local citizens in the workforce (GLMM, 2018).

The nationality breakdown reflects the Gulf's historic and geographic connections to the rest of the Middle East, South Asia, and the Horn of Africa (GLMM, 2019). Asian migrants make up the majority of the total non-national population across the region, from a low of 58% in Kuwait to a

high of 90% in Oman. Kuwait has the highest proportion of Arab migrants (39%), followed by Oman (17%) and the UAE (13%). Europeans and North Americans (excluding military personnel) are an insignificant proportion of the Gulf's foreign population, averaging around 3% combined in Qatar and the UAE, and about 2% in Bahrain and Kuwait. Across the Gulf, expatriate workers represent the majority of the private sector labour forces, with Gulf nationals more likely to be employed within the public sector (GLMM, 2019).

The *kafala* labour sponsorship system is critical to the treatment of all migrant workers in the Gulf region, including HSM, and is regularly blamed for the mistreatment and exploitation of foreign workers in the region (Kanchana, 2018). By making the GCC citizen or business responsible for a migrant's presence, the state can both control migration and privatize its enforcement. Thus, the *kafala* is a business system and a sponsorship system alike (Roper & Barria, 2014).

3.3.1. Saudi Arabia

The Saudi Vision 2030 aims to diversify the Saudi economy, make Saudi Arabia into a global investment hub, improve employment opportunities for locals, and attract talent that is needed to develop key economic sectors (KSA, 2016). Currently, the country does not offer any permanent residency to adult expatriates entering the country (Zahra, 2018). However, a foreigner can buy residential or commercial real estate after approval from the Ministry of Interior. Recently, the government announced that it is developing a 'green card' for foreign investors and highly qualified experts, enabling them to sponsor themselves (rather than be sponsored by a local citizen or company), obtain permanent residency, buy property, and run businesses (De Bel-Air, 2018b).

In 2018, about 12.6 million migrants were in Saudi Arabia: 24% from India, 20% from Pakistan, 15% from Bangladesh, and 15% from Egypt. Saudi Arabia relies on Asian and other Arab workers primarily for its skilled expatriate workforce, with a small minority from Western countries (GLMM, 2019). Its main goal is to increase the employment rates of local citizens and limit medium- and low-skill migrants in the country by implementing additional monthly taxes per foreign employee on companies with higher numbers of foreign workers (De Bel-Air, 2018b). Since 2011, Saudi Arabia has taken several effective measures to boost Saudi employment, most prominently the Nitaqat system (Peck, 2017), which outlines Saudization (nationalization) quotas for different industries, classifying companies based on their number of Saudi employees, penalizing those companies that do not achieve quotas, and setting a minimum wage for Saudi citizens working in the private sector. The Nitaqat system has resulted in a gradual decline in foreigners across many sectors of the economy, though the percentage of workers in highly skilled categories grew from around 11% to 18.5% of all permit-holders (De Bel-Air, 2018b). In 2015, approximately 8 million labour permits were issued, of which 1.5 million were for specialists, managers, and technicians.

3.3.2. Other Gulf states

Citizenship is rarely granted but most Gulf countries have similar requirements, including having legal residency for at least 25 years (fewer for Arab nationals), good conduct, Arabic fluency, and registered real estate in the country (Babar, 2014). Since 2010, foreign employment has increased in these countries, but most workers are low-skilled migrants in the construction and retail sectors, unlikely to obtain citizenship or compete with Gulf nationals for jobs. These states recognize that certain highly skilled foreigners are required more intensely in key post-oil sectors and specialized occupations. Many highly skilled South and Southeast Asian migrants use working in the Gulf as a platform to migrate to North America (Ewers, 2013; Percot, 2006).

There is also some variation in the determinants of highly skilled labour attraction and retention that differ across the Gulf countries. For example, Qatar does not have the same number of immigrants in higher-paying positions where a long-term, post-contract settlement could be a desirable option for HSM and their families. Oman, meanwhile, is intent on reducing the number of higher wage expatriates in the country, with a strong focus on steadily increasing the number of Omani workers in skilled public and private sector positions (Arab News, 2019).

4. Discussion and conclusion

This review of the literature and key case studies of highly skilled migration to emerging economies sheds light on recent dynamics shaping the geography of human capital, thereby challenging some of the fundamental assumptions about contemporary migration dynamics. In particular, we emphasized how emerging economies as HSM destinations shape global talent mobility via their national immigration and workforce regulations, local labour market processes, and international labour supply and demand dynamics.

First, we identified three prominent strategies towards attracting and utilizing global talent for local development. Each of the strategies comprises unique regulatory frameworks for immigration and employment which differ from the liberal immigration states of the West. Dubai and Singapore each seek to serve as global hubs for talent in a post-industrial world, investing heavily in globally competitive higher education systems, leveraging geopolitical and trade ties to attract multinational corporations, and offering long-term visas and permanent residency for highly skilled foreigners. India and Malaysia are engaging with their large and spatially expansive diasporas while contending with sizable skilled local populations. While India is focused on developing investment and business ties with its diaspora, Malaysia is seeking to attract its back. Saudi Arabia and the other Arab Gulf States are more intent on utilizing foreign knowledge workers as a temporary tool to build local human capital by developing and modifying the *kafala* labour sponsorship system to ensure flexible access to foreign workers and maximum control. However, future research should focus more on specific policy outcomes.

Second, we demonstrated that new analytical perspectives are needed to capture the determinants of HSM attraction and mobility to emerging economies. Conventional skilled migration research has emphasized the global nature of talent mobility. Yet, one of the strongest determinants of mobility is geographic proximity, and there is an important regional component to HSM dynamics in emerging economies. Economic ties and geographic proximity between South Asia and the Gulf have led to higher levels of migration, while Southeast Asian economies support intra-regional labour migration. In Singapore, policy moves in the 1990s led to a greater number of professionals being recruited from India and China (Yeoh & Lam, 2016). In Malaysia, Talent-Corp's MyASEAN Internship programme connects Malaysian job seekers with top ASEAN companies. Alongside these regional dynamics, the movement of professionals is further divided across occupations and sectoral specializations (Hugo 2014). Yet, research has shown that attracting and retaining talent is about more than income for HSM; greater security and stability, quality of life, or socio-cultural proximity can each be core drivers. Future research should employ a more comparative approach to reexamine existing assumptions based on Western destinations.

Finally, labour markets vary across countries and cities according to the state regulatory frameworks and skilled labour supply and demand dynamics, and local perceptions and receptivity towards foreigners. Our research validates this point and demonstrates the need for more in-depth research on the geographically specific labour market outcomes manifested in the cases

examined. In each case, foreign workers are differentially incorporated in labour markets which are segmented according to skill, nationality, and gender, resulting in a migrant division of labour. Additionally, governments and businesses who want to attract foreign talent will need to manage local employment rates and anti-migrant, nationalist sentiments. For example, in the Gulf states, labour nationalization programmes which are designed to increase the proportion of citizens in key occupations and sectors may lead to HSM insecurity. In Singapore and Malaysia, governments hire skilled migrants where local skills are lacking. However, these countries' relatively new policies may not include protections for foreign workers, resulting in precarity for skilled migrants (Zhan & Zhou, 2020). More research is needed to learn specifically how local labour market dynamics in emerging economies shape the lives of skilled foreign workers.

Despite the global economic and political prominence of the countries examined, none have the same quality or availability of data on HSM as found across most OECD member states. Similarly, the lack of individual-level data makes it difficult to conduct more sophisticated quantitative analysis (Fong & Shibuya, 2020). Researchers, in consequence, have been more inclined towards qualitative methods. However, the greater availability of data on Western destinations draws the attention of more empirically oriented social scientists. Thus, the lack of availability of data on HSM to the developing world reinforces the exclusion of these countries from the dominant scholarly discourse. Our suggestion for scholars is to focus their efforts on fielding high-quality, representative business surveys in particular sectors in these countries, or public opinion surveys in key cities or regions in these countries. A less costly alternative would be to fund fully online survey panels of high skilled migrants in these places, utilizing Qualtrics, Facebook, or Amazon MTURK survey tools (Boas et al., 2020). These surveys should also go beyond the data collected by official agencies, and the questions examined by most conventional studies, by asking more questions about race, ethnicity, gender, and the lived experiences of skilled migrants from diverse backgrounds in emerging economies.

In many ways, the literature on highly skilled international labour migration has emerged alongside the globalization literature. Two key trends have occurred in the past 5 years that have challenged this, with yet-to-be-seen implications for global talent mobility. First, 2016 brought Brexit and the election of Donald Trump, both of which reflect the rise of nationalism and legislation aimed at stemming migration (skilled and unskilled) into Western countries. Second, 2020 brought the global pandemic of Covid-19, which has revealed the inherent risks of a more connected world, as most countries have restricted the movement of foreigners into their countries. On the surface, both trends could point towards declining levels of migration overall, including highly skilled migration. Yet, the push towards more nationally oriented economies and less porous borders in Western countries could provide an important opportunity for emerging economies if they maintain their relative openness, retain talent that may have left, and attract new flows of talent from the West and other emerging economies.

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